

THE POWER OF PREDICTION

almanacs and calendars

In the 16th and 17th centuries, almanacs were much more common than scholarly books on astrology. Rather like a modern diary, they contained practical information, beginning with church festivals, feast days, and market days, followed by more specific astronomical sections, with times of sunrises and sunsets. Astrological predictions about the weather, crops, and politics followed the practical section. Although their roots stretched back to the omen tablets of 1st-century BCE Babylon, it was only after the

invention of printing that almanacs became widespread, as they could then be produced and distributed rapidly and cheaply.

Johannes Gutenberg, the inventor of movable type, published the first printed almanac in 1448. Almanacs

spread rapidly through France and Germany, and reached England in the 1490s when the Italian astrologer William

Parron produced one. By the early 17th century they had reached the British colonies in North America, with *An Almanac for New England* printed in 1639 in association with Harvard College.

Craze for almanacs

Almanacs had a wide appeal—around a million were sold in England between 1664 and 1666 alone. *The Shepherd's Calendars*, published in France from the late 15th century, were aimed at humble folk, but the allure of their prophetic sections meant that the aristocracy also bought them, and one copy even found its way into the library of the king, François I. Almanacs dealt with higher matters, too, especially with

► Agricultural advice

This 16th-century English almanac contains saint's days and predictions about the effect of signs of the zodiac (here Libra and Scorpio) on agriculture and rural life.



▲ Runic reminder

This 16th-century Norwegian wooden almanac is written in runes, the traditional Norse script. It includes a list of religious holidays, the feast days of saints, and important days for the agricultural calendar, such as the start of winter.

